

Psalms 82

Ye Are Gods

I have said, Ye are gods... but ye shall die like men
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *God standeth in the congregation of the mighty; he judgeth among the gods.*
- 2 *How long will ye judge unjustly, and accept the persons of the wicked? Selah.*
- 3 *Defend the poor and fatherless: do justice to the afflicted and needy.*
- 4 *Deliver the poor and needy: rid them out of the hand of the wicked.*
- 5 *They know not, neither will they understand; they walk on in darkness: all the foundations of the earth are out of course.*
- 6 *I have said, Ye are gods; and all of you are children of the most High.*
- 7 *But ye shall die like men, and fall like one of the princes.*
- 8 *Arise, O God, judge the earth: for thou shalt inherit all nations.*

2 · CONTEXT

A brief but pointed psalm in which God stands in judgment over human judges and rulers—called 'gods' as those entrusted with His delegated authority to administer justice—and indicts them for favoring the wicked while neglecting the poor and fatherless. Jesus cites verse 6 in John 10:34 to argue that if Scripture calls mere human officials 'gods' by virtue of their office, His own claim to divine sonship should not be dismissed as blasphemy. Henry reads the psalm primarily as a warning to those in any position of earthly authority.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

God is pictured presiding over an assembly of the 'gods'—human judges and rulers holding delegated authority—and confronts them directly: how long will you judge unjustly and show partiality to the wicked? The corrective is concrete and specific: defend the poor and fatherless, do justice for the afflicted and needy, deliver them from the hand of the wicked.

Verse 5-8

The indictment sharpens: these rulers neither know nor understand, walking in darkness while the very foundations of the earth are shaken by their failure. Despite their exalted title—I said you are gods, children of the Most High—they will die like any other mortal, falling like any prince. The psalm closes with an appeal for God Himself to arise and judge the earth, since He alone rightly inherits all nations.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Human authority, however exalted its title or office, remains accountable to God for how it treats the poor and vulnerable, and no position shields anyone from ultimately dying like any other mortal. The psalm exposes the gap between the dignity of delegated authority and the responsibility that dignity actually requires—authority exists to protect the weak, not merely to be enjoyed.

Application for life today.

If you hold any position of authority—in a family, workplace, church, or community—let this psalm's indictment examine how consistently you defend the poor and vulnerable rather than favor the comfortable or powerful. Remember that no title, however elevated, exempts anyone from ultimate accountability to God; use that truth to resist both the intimidation of unjust power and the temptation to abuse whatever power you hold. Pray verse 8's closing appeal over unjust systems you cannot personally fix.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. In what sphere of influence—however small—are you tempted to favor the comfortable over the vulnerable, as this psalm indicts (vv. 2–4)?

2. How does remembering that even the most exalted human authority will 'die like men' (v. 7) reshape your response to unjust power?

3. What would it look like this week to concretely 'defend the poor and fatherless' rather than merely sympathize with them (v. 3)?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).